

TRIAD TYPES

The 6 essential triads — 4 quality-based and 2 suspended. Each has a distinct emotional signature built from two stacked 3rds (or 2nds and 4ths for sus chords).

THE 6 TRIAD TYPES (ALL SHOWN FROM ROOT C)

MAJOR

MAJOR

C – E – G

1 – 3 – 5

M3 (4 semitones) + m3 (3 semitones)

BRIGHT STABLE HAPPY

The foundation of major harmony. Confident, resolved, culturally associated with happiness and completion.

MINOR

MINOR

C – E $\flat$ – G

1 – $\flat$ 3 – 5

m3 (3 semitones) + M3 (4 semitones)

DARK MELANCHOLIC

INTROSPECTIVE

The lowered 3rd is the only difference from major — yet completely changes the emotional character. Darker, softer, more inward.

DIMINISHED

DIMINISHED

C – E $\flat$ – G $\flat$

1 – $\flat$ 3 – $\flat$ 5

m3 (3 semitones) + m3 (3 semitones)

TENSE UNSTABLE TRITONE

Two stacked minor 3rds. Contains the tritone ($\flat$ 3 to $\flat$ 5). Unstable by nature — functions as a passing or dominant substitute chord.

AUGMENTED

AUGMENTED

C – E – G $\sharp$

1 – 3 – $\sharp$ 5

M3 (4 semitones) + M3 (4 semitones)

DREAMLIKE SUSPENDED

UNRESOLVED

Two stacked major 3rds. Symmetrical — no single root sounds "correct." Floaty and unresolved, yearning to move somewhere. Used in chromatic passing contexts.

SUSPENDED 2ND

SUS2

C – D – G

1 – 2 – 5

M2 (2 semitones) + P4 (5 semitones)

OPEN STATIONARY SPACIOUS

The 3rd is replaced by the 2nd — neither major nor minor. Low tension, ambient, "waiting." The 2nd creates gentle color without strong directional pull.

SUSPENDED 4TH

SUS4

C – F – G

1 – 4 – 5

P4 (5 semitones) + M2 (2 semitones)

HIGH TENSION YEARNING

WANTS TO RESOLVE

The 4th wants to "fall" down a half step to the 3rd. More tension than Sus2. Classic use: V7sus4 → V7 → I (see F/G voicings). "Desperado" by Eagles.

KEY DISTINCTIONS

SUSPENDED CHORDS HAVE NO 3RD

Without a 3rd, suspended chords are neither major nor minor — they're ambiguous by design. This creates a floating quality that resolves when the suspension "falls" to the 3rd (sus4 → major) or lifts (sus2 → major).

SUS4 HAS MORE TENSION THAN SUS2

The 4th degree is an inherently unstable scale tone that wants to resolve downward. The 2nd degree is also unstable but creates less urgency. Sus4 creates expectation; Sus2 creates openness.